Sans Merci

By Johnna Adams

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: ***Actress 1*** *– Kelly;* ***Actress 2*** *– Elizabeth and Tracy*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 2: *We see it in the headlines: Peacekeepers killed in Mali, in the Central African Republic, in Columbia.*
ACTRESS 1: *Names and faces become merely blips on the historical fabric of oppression, domination and brutality throughout the world.*
ACTRESS 2: *But these idealistic young men and women are so much more than a passing headline.*
ACTRESS 1: *Sans Merci (Without Mercy) by Johnna Adams tells the story of Tracy and Kelly, young college students determined to make a difference by helping the U'wa Indians in Colombia.*
ACTRESS 2: *But when the mission erupts into violence . . . who is left to put the shattered pieces together again?*
TOGETHER: *Sans Merci by Johnna Adams*

Scene opens with Kelly asleep on the couch, a cane by her side. Elizabeth consults a piece of paper and finds the apartment number on Kelly's door. She knocks. Kelly is startled awake, retrieves her cane and opens the front door.

KELLY: **(Pg 8)** Yes?

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 10)** I'm Elizabeth Bird . . . from Chicago. We've never met, but we've spoken on the phone. Once or twice.

KELLY: You're Tracy's mom. *(she steps back to allow Elizabeth to enter)* How did you get my address?

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 15-16)** *(Ignoring the question)* You two met in a literature class?

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KELLY: Feminist Studies in Art and Literature. She did a presentation. . . on Keats . . . La Belle Dame Sans Merci

TRACY: **(Pg 33)** *(Tracy steps out of the scene and speak to the audience)* I met a lady in the meads, / Full beautiful—a faery's child, / Her hair was long, her foot was light, / And her eyes were wild. . . . **(Pg 28)** My mother has a degree in poetry. Almost a PhD. I was raised on Keats the way other kids were raised on Sesame Street. I love him.

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 16)** So that's feminist literature now. La Belle Dame Sans Merci? That's what the feminists all really want. Feminism at its core is more about female superiority than equality. *(Kelly shifts her weight to relieve pressure on her leg)* **(Pg 18-19)** It must be difficult learning to do things with that cane.

KELLY: It's fine.

ELIZABETH: Will it get better? Your leg?

KELLY: No. it won't

ELIZABETH: I think I read that you'd been injured. I didn't know how serious it was.

KELLY: **(Pg 20-22)** I don't mean to be short. I don't mean to be unkind. What did you want?

ELIZABETH: Well, most of our information about what happened came to us second- or third-hand . . . We did eventually get her body back. In a sealed casket. But we never got the things she took to Colombia. I thought you might have them.

KELLY: I do. I have her backpack. The clothes they cut off her when they raped us. I have her last journal. Those are the things I have. I'll get them. *(Kelly is shaken, but crosses to the bedroom door)*

ELIZABETH: And there was something else. *(Kelly turns; Elizabeth pulls a pride flag out of her handbag; her hands are shaking)* This was in the box the girl from the university sent. It's a pride flag, I think. I don't know why she had it. *(silence)* Were you and Tracy lovers?

****** flash back *******

KELLY: **(Pg 28-30)** So you really opened my eyes. To Keats . . . Are you a poetry major?

TRACY: Literature. What's your major?

KELLY: Political Sciences. I'm going to Colombia this summer. To help the U'wa Indians. The Occidental Petroleum Corporation is stealing their lands to extract fossil fuels. We're going to help them organize.

TRACY: Is it dangerous? *(their hands touch . . . andawkward moment)*

KELLY: No. The U'was reservation is surrounded by rebel forces. They control almost half of Colombia right now. But they're on our side, and we have their permission to be there.

TRACY: But you're risking your life. I mean, those rebels have guns. Something might happen.

KELLY: They would never kill US citizens . . . Don't let me talk your ear off about the U'was. I get crazy excited about it and go on and on.

TRACY: I think that's great. You're passionate about things. Do you want to get something to eat? Maybe coffee?

****** back to present day ******

KELLY: **(Pg 34-43)** We were friends. Best friends. That's all.

ELIZABETH: You said you had her last journal . . . The one I have stops a few months before she met you. So [it] must be from the time she met you to just before she died. *(all business)* Could you get it?

KELLY: *(makes a small noise)* It's . . . It's private . . . please.

ELIZABETH: I was having a phone conversation with her once. And I heard giggling. But not from her. From someone else. A female voice. But close to the phone. Like someone had their mouth very near hers. And Tracy said, "shush." Softly. Just "shush.' Very tender. And I knew. But I didn't say anything. Because I hoped I was wrong.

KELLY: She said you wouldn't understand. She said you voted to support some state initiative. Marriage means a man and a woman. You wanted grandchildren. *(Beat)* She loved you so much. She wanted you to be proud of her.

ELIZABETH: You know, I don't think I've ever been in a lesbian apartment before.

KELLY: The apartment's asexual. I'm the lesbian.

ELIZABETH: Was that an insulting remark? I lost all capacity for tact when my daughter's mutilated body was returned to me in a sealed box. *(Looking around the apartment)* I don't know what I expected in a lesbian's apartment. I guess more flags like the one I got in the mail. *(She notices a poster on the wall)* Who is this?

KELLY: Lech Walesa . . . The Polish labor organizer. From the Solidarity movement.

ELIZABETH: And this?

KELLY: Cesar Chavez. He was a Mexican labor leader and organizer . .

ELIZABETH: I know how he was. Thank you. You really seem to identify with the wrong sort of people. People that mobs of violent peasants want to tear limb from limb.

KELLY: Lech Walesa is a former president of Poland. He won the Nobel Prize. No one tore him limb form limb. He's alive . . .

ELIZABETH: People wanted to kill him.

KELLY: People wanted to kill Gandhi.

ELIZABETH: Exactly. I wouldn't consider him a role model either.

KELLY: He stood up for an entire nation when no one else had the guts to. He changed the world!

ELIZABETH: He put his family in jeopardy. It's a miracle he wasn't tortured to death like my daughter. *(Long pause)*

KELLY: *(with passion)* So, the world you want to live in is a world where nobody stands up for freedom? Where we all just accept persecution to be safe. I can't accept that. Somebody has to step out of the crowd and say, "this is unacceptable."

ELIZABETH: Oh, don't get worked up. I don't care about Gandhi. I just wanted to see it.

KELLY: See what?

ELIZABETH: What Tracy died for.

KELLY: You . . . blame . . . me?

ELIZABETH: Of course, I blame you. My daughter was a literature major. She was going to a student-led bible study. She voted republican like her father and me. She had a crush on a boy who worked as a sports' editor on the college newspaper. I want that boy for her. Because I can think of a thousand ways [he] might have ruined her life. But he wouldn't have ended it! He wouldn't have taken her where you took her.

KELLY: His name was Joshua. He was gay.

ELIZABETH: Oh . . . Terrific. Another one. *(Long silence)*

KELLY: **(Pg 72-75)** Don't you . . . *(sighs)* . . . Don't you want to know . . . what happened?

ELIZABETH: How she died? *(she steels herself)* Yes. I do.

KELLY: We had been in the U'wa village for three days. We thought we were safe. Tracy and I took the camera and went to get footage of the cliffs for a documentary film we were making –

ELIZABETH: It was a video camera?

KELLY: *(quickly)* There isn't any footage of her . . . Just stills. *(Beat)* The cliff site is sacred. And they let us go up there alone. See there are two rebel armies in Colombia. Sometimes they're allies. We had permission from the ELN* to be in the village. And we thought that they would have cleared it with the FARC**. The other group of rebels. Right? They told us it was safe. But they didn't. And it wasn't safe. The FARC didn't see the value in having stupid American kids working on their behalf. They thought we'd be more valuable as hostages. That they could get money from our families.

ELIZABETH: Why didn't they keep you as hostages?

KELLY: *(makes a small noise)* Because I fought.

****** flashback to the cliff *******

TRACY: **(Pg 76)** Oh, Kel! Oh, God! It's beautiful! I've never seen anything so beautiful. When my mom sees something this beautiful she quotes Keats . . . **(Pg 83-84)** I saw pale kings and princes too, / Pale warriors, death-pale were they all; /They cried—'La Belle Dame sans Merci / Thee hath in thrall!' *(the girls hear a noise in the brush. They freeze)*

KELLY: Don't move. Don't attract their attention

TRACY: *(whispers)* What do they want? You think it's the ELN?

KELLY: Probably. They're speaking Spanish. They said the word Americans.

TRACY: They're looking for us!

KELLY: I want you to go back to the village. I'll make a lot of noise and they'll follow me. Find the cellphone coverage area. Call for help. I love you.

TRACY: I love you, too.

****** Present day ******

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 86)** . . . They found you. Alone. On the cliffs.

KELLY: Yes. I told them to rape me and leave Tracy alone. Two of them held me down. . . When it was over they went for Tracy. And I fought them . . . Then the leader pulled out a pistol and shot me in the leg. And Tracy screamed . . . they dragged me over to the edge of the cliff and all I could do was watch. They raped her. And when they were done, she started pleading with the soldiers. To not put me so close to the edge. She told them I was scared of heights. Oh, Tracy . . . She thought they would care or something. And then the leader pushed me off the cliff. There was a ledge about 60 feet down the face of the cliff. And I slammed into the ledge. My leg shattered. But I survived. I knew I was dying, but I didn't know what had happened to Tracy. I thought she was alive. I thought she was a hostage . . . So I couldn't die. The U'wa found me the next afternoon.

Tracy was dead. They carried me over to her body. I waited with her until they brought the trucks. I held her hand. . . The soldiers had shot her in the head.

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 88)** Do you think she fought them? *(Kelly makes a small noise)* Do you know how long she lived, after you were pushed? If she was tortured? *(Kelly can't speak) (Long silence)* **(Pg 90)** Well . . . *(She takes Kelly's hand)* I do think . . . as much as anybody can be in love in this world, you were in love with my daughter . . . It doesn't mean that I don't wish you had never been born. And for Tracy's part, I still hope she didn't love you . . . But . . . I . . . imagine she did. *(Elizabeth goes to the door to leave but Kelly stops her)*

KELLY: **(Pg 91-93)** There's something else. Something of hers I didn't tell you about. I was recording with the digital camera just before the soldiers found us. I put it in Tracy's backpack. I forgot to turn it off. There's no picture . . . but you can hear everything. It's really hard to listen to . . but if you want, you can hear what happened after they pushed me . . . you can hear what she said. *(Elizabeth nods and Kelly pushes the play button on the recorder)*

TRACY: Murderers! Bastards! She was good! I loved her! This was wrong and I was here to see it! Rapists! Your mothers should find you and kill you! They should spit in your faces. I will find where you live! I WON'T STOP TELLING PEOPLE WHAT YOU DID! I WON'T STOP TELLING PEOPLE UNTIL THE WORLD KNOWS! You'll have to kill me! I'll come for you in the night with razors! With stones! *(Tracy is shot in the back of the head and Kelly breaks down)*

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 16)** Full beautiful – a faery's child / Her hair was long, her foot was light . . .. And her eyes were wild.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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** The National Liberation Army (ELN) is a revolutionary left-wing armed group involved in the continuing Colombian conflict, which has existed in Colombia since 1964. The ELN advocates a composite communist ideology of Marxism-Leninism and liberation theology.*

***The Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC) They were founded in 1964 as the armed wing of the Communist Party and follow a Marxist-Leninist ideology.*

Additional information about FARC and ELN can be found here
https://www.files.ethz.ch/isn/186229/FARC,%20ELN_%20Colombia%27s%20Left-Wing%20Guerrillas.pdf

Poem: La Belle Dame sans Merci: A Ballad by John Keats
Full text can be found here https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/44475/la-belle-dame-sans-merci-a-ballad

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